

L2b: Yield, Duration, Convexity, and the Yield Curve

CHEME 5660 Cornell University

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Scenario

It is 6:30 AM at your trading desk. You are responsible for a \$500 million portfolio of Treasury securities. The Federal Reserve meets today, and the rumor is a half-point move in the policy rate. The phone is already ringing.

By 2:00 PM you need an answer to one question: how much does this portfolio move?

That question has a precise answer, and today we build it. The tools are the slope and the curvature of the price-yield relationship, and a vocabulary for saying which rate actually moved.

Careful: a half-point move in the *policy rate* is not a half-point move in *your security's yield*. We return to that.

Objectives for Today

Today we take the fixed-income price model from L2a and ask how its price responds to a change in the rate used to discount it.

Today's concepts

- **Price-yield geometry**: explain why a fixed positive cash-flow stream has a decreasing, convex price-yield curve.
- **Duration and convexity**: define both measures, estimate the local price effect of a yield change, and interpret their units.
- **Yield-curve vocabulary**: distinguish yield to maturity, par yield, spot rates, and the discount factors that price individual cash flows.

Companion notes: [L2b lecture notes and notebooks](#)

Lectures and Examples

Lecture:

CHEME-5660-L2b-Lecture-Yield-Duration-Convexity-Curve-Fall-2026.ipynb

The required example prices a coupon Treasury security and studies how its price responds to a change in yield and to a change in the coupon rate.

Example:

CHEME-5660-L2b-Example-Treasury-Duration-Convexity-Fall-2026.ipynb

The longer theorem exercise and the term-structure notebooks stay available as optional extensions under advanced/.

Link: <https://github.com/varnerlab/CHEME-5660-CourseRepository-Fall-2026.git>

Quick review before we start: a safe payment can still have a risky price.

Concept Review: Are Treasury Securities Really Risk-Free?

No. Treasuries carry low default risk because they are obligations of the U.S. government, which is why the rate you declare is so often taken from them. That label is conditional. Two of the surviving risks matter today.

- **Default risk:** the issuer fails to pay. The United States has never repudiated its debt, though a 1979 operational failure did delay payment on some maturing bills. Other sovereigns have defaulted outright: Greece restructured its privately held debt in 2012, Russia defaulted in 1998.
- **Interest-rate risk:** if required yields change, the secondary-market value of a fixed promised cash flow changes. An institution that marks positions to market is affected even without a sale.

Today: interest-rate risk is the one we can compute. Its size depends on maturity, coupon, yield, and the shock.

Case Study: Interest Rate Risk and Silicon Valley Bank

SVB held a large portfolio of **long-maturity fixed-rate** government securities bought while rates were low. As the Federal Reserve raised rates through 2022 and 2023, the value of those securities fell.

- The losses were unrealized, so a hold-to-maturity story obscured them.
- In early March 2023 uninsured depositors withdrew funds. SVB announced a capital raise to cover realized bond losses, and the bank failed.
- The FDIC took control on March 10, 2023, with roughly \$209 billion in assets: then the second largest failure of an insured bank on record, now the third.

Rate sensitivity was one component of a coupled balance-sheet and liquidity problem, not a complete explanation by itself.

Overview: [the collapse of Silicon Valley Bank, from PBS](#)

Zero-Coupon Treasury Bill

Start with the simplest security: a bill that pays nothing until maturity and then returns its face value. It is the hydrogen atom of fixed income.

Let $V_P > 0$ be the face value, $T > 0$ the remaining maturity in years, n the number of compounding intervals per year, and y the nominal annual yield used to discount the single promised payment. Write $q := 1 + y/n$ for the per-period growth factor, so the L2a discount factor is $\mathcal{D}_{nT,0}^{-1}(y) = q^{-nT}$. The price is given by:

$$V_B = \underbrace{q^{-nT}}_{\text{discount}} V_P.$$

Standing assumption: $y > 0$ throughout this lecture, as it has been for the Treasury data we use. Several results below fail without it, and we flag each place where it does real work.

Deriving the Price Sensitivity

Three quantities could move the price: the yield y , the annual coupon rate $\bar{c}$, and the maturity T . A bill's contract fixes $\bar{c} = 0$ permanently, so $d\bar{c} = 0$ and that channel is closed. Holding V_P and n fixed, the remaining two channels give the total differential:

$$dV_B = \underbrace{-V_P q^{-nT} \left(\frac{T}{q} \right)}_{V_{B,y}} dy - \underbrace{V_P q^{-nT} (n \ln q)}_{V_{B,T}} dT.$$

Stated carefully: the coupon channel does *not* drop out because a bill pays no coupons. The coupon-bearing family of the next section has $\partial V_B / \partial \bar{c} = (V_P / n) \sum_j q^{-j} > 0$, which stays strictly positive even when evaluated at $\bar{c} = 0$. A bill is not insensitive to coupons: it is a security whose coupon cannot move.

Is the Maturity Channel Legitimate?

A bill promises one payment, so its price depends on T only through the exponent nT . No intermediate payment can be added or removed, so $\partial V_B / \partial T$ is well defined here. But two experiments hide behind the symbol dT :

- **Changing the contractual maturity:** comparing a 6-month bill with a 12-month bill compares two securities issued on different terms. Smooth for a bill, because only the exponent changes. Not smooth for a coupon security, where it adds or removes scheduled payments.
- **The passage of time:** holding one bill, calendar time t advances while remaining maturity falls, so $dT = -dt$ along the position. Smooth for a bill over the whole holding period. For a coupon security, smooth only between coupon dates.

Later: both distinctions return when we price coupon-bearing notes and bonds.

The Two Sensitivity Magnitudes

Read $V_{B,y}$ and $V_{B,T}$ as **magnitudes**, not as the derivatives themselves: the derivatives are their negatives, which is why the minus signs appear explicitly above. Under the standing assumption $y > 0$, both are positive:

$$V_{B,y} = \underbrace{V_P q^{-nT}}_{=V_B} \underbrace{\left(\frac{T}{q}\right)}_{>0}, \quad V_{B,T} = \underbrace{V_P q^{-nT}}_{=V_B} \underbrace{(n \ln q)}_{=g_y},$$

where $g_y := n \ln q$ is the continuously compounded equivalent of y from L2a.

Given a well-posed price, $q > 0$, the first magnitude is positive for any $T > 0$. The second needs $y > 0$, because g_y carries the sign of y : at $y = 0$ maturity stops mattering, and for $-n < y < 0$ a longer bill would be worth *more* and would trade above par.

Careful: negative nominal yields have occurred in other sovereign markets. State the condition.

What This Says to Us: the Bill

Decreasing in the yield

Holding maturity fixed, a higher yield discounts the face value more heavily, so $V_B \downarrow$ as $y \uparrow$. Buy a 52-week bill at auction; if the yield moves from 2% to 3%, the secondary-market price falls below what you paid.

Decreasing in the time to maturity

Holding the yield fixed at a positive value, $V_B \downarrow$ as $T \uparrow$. But while you *hold* the bill, calendar time advances and the remaining maturity falls, so $dT < 0$: six months in, with the yield unchanged, the price is *higher* than you paid, because fewer periods remain to discount. At $y = 0$ exactly, every discount factor is one and the price does not move at all.

Optional extension: advanced/malkiel/, which develops the full maturity comparison on Treasury bill auction data.

Coupon-Bearing Treasury Notes and Bonds

Now let the security pay coupons. Let $\bar{c}$ be the annual coupon rate, written c in L2a, so each payment is $C := (\bar{c}/n)V_P$, and let $N := nT$ be the number of remaining payment dates, indexed by $j = 1, \dots, N$. From L2a the price is given by:

$$V_B = \mathcal{D}_{N,0}^{-1}(y) V_P + C \sum_{j=1}^N \mathcal{D}_{j,0}^{-1}(y), \quad \mathcal{D}_{j,0}^{-1}(y) = q^{-j}.$$

Holding that cash-flow schedule fixed, the yield and coupon sensitivities are:

$$\frac{\partial V_B}{\partial y} = -\frac{1}{nq} \left[NV_P q^{-N} + C \sum_{j=1}^N j q^{-j} \right] < 0, \quad \frac{\partial V_B}{\partial \bar{c}} = \frac{V_P}{n} \sum_{j=1}^N q^{-j} > 0.$$

Careful: N is a discrete schedule index. Differentiating a finite sum whose upper limit is nT with respect to a smooth T is not a valid total differential.

What This Says to Us: Notes and Bonds

- **Decreasing in the yield:** now *both* the coupons and the final principal are discounted more heavily, so $V_B \downarrow$ as $y \uparrow$.
- **Increasing in the coupon rate, but not proportional to it:** $\partial V_B / \partial \bar{c}$ does not depend on $\bar{c}$, and the discounted par payment survives even at $\bar{c} = 0$. Doubling the coupon doubles the coupon stream, not the price.
- **Maturity does not set the price direction by itself:** a **discount bond** ($\bar{c} < y$) drifts up toward par as maturity shortens, a **premium bond** ($\bar{c} > y$) drifts down toward par, and a **par bond** ($\bar{c} = y$) sits at par on a coupon date.

Careful: Malkiel's maturity result is about *sensitivity to a yield change*, not about the price level.

Duration and Convexity

The derivatives so far answer *which direction*. Risk management needs *how much*, in units comparable across positions of different size.

Everything here assumes an **option-free** security: one whose promised cash flows are fixed in advance and do not change when yields change. Conventional noncallable Treasuries qualify; callable, inflation-indexed, and mortgage-backed securities do not.

Let N be the number of remaining periods and $X_j \geq 0$ the dollar cash flow at period j , with at least one $X_j > 0$. Then one expression covers both securities:

$$V_B(y) = \sum_{j=1}^N X_j q^{-j}.$$

A note pays $X_j = C$ for $j < N$ and $X_N = C + V_P$; a bill pays $X_j = 0$ for $j < N$ and $X_N = V_P$.

Two Derivatives, One Shape

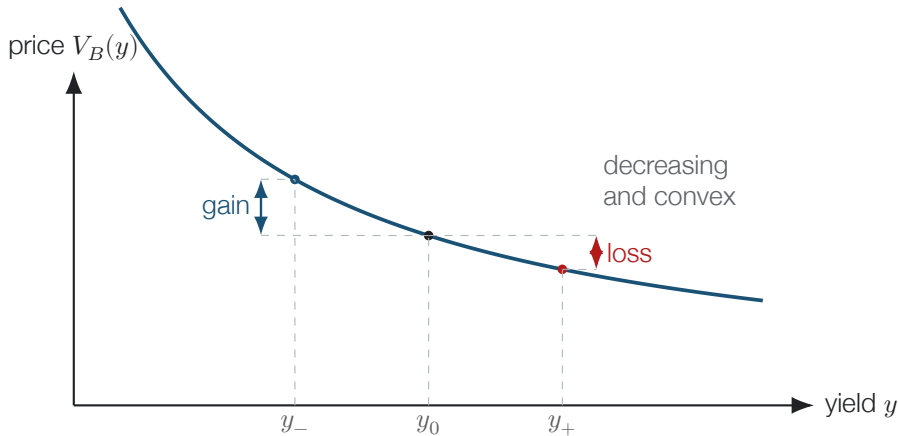
Differentiate the price twice with respect to the yield, holding the cash flows X_j and the schedule length N fixed:

$$\frac{dV_B}{dy} = -\frac{1}{n} \sum_{j=1}^N j X_j q^{-j-1} < 0, \quad \frac{d^2V_B}{dy^2} = \frac{1}{n^2} \sum_{j=1}^N j(j+1) X_j q^{-j-2} > 0.$$

The strict signs follow from $q > 0$ and from at least one X_j being strictly positive: no term of either sum is negative, and at least one term of each is positive.

So the price-yield curve is **decreasing** and **strictly convex**. That second fact is called **positive convexity**, and it is what makes the price response asymmetric.

The Price-Yield Curve



Equal yield moves $y_{\pm} := y_0 \pm \Delta y$, for $\Delta y > 0$, from the same starting yield y_0 . Convexity makes the **gain** exceed the **loss**.

The Two Risk Measures

Dividing each derivative by the price removes the size of the position and leaves two local risk measures. With $V_B(y) > 0$ the price at yield y , the **modified duration** and the **convexity** are given by:

$$D_{\text{mod}}(y) := -\frac{1}{V_B(y)} \frac{dV_B}{dy}, \quad K(y) := \frac{1}{V_B(y)} \frac{d^2V_B}{dy^2}.$$

Both are positive by the signs just established. With y a decimal per year, D_{mod} has units of years and K units of years squared.

Modified is not Macaulay. The **Macaulay duration** D_{mac} is the present-value-weighted average time to payment, and $D_{\text{mod}} = D_{\text{mac}}/(1 + y/n)$. For a bill, every dollar arrives at maturity, so $D_{\text{mac}} = T$ and $D_{\text{mod}} = T/q$, which is exactly the ratio $V_{B,y}/V_B$ we derived earlier.

Using Them: the Second-Order Price Approximation

A second-order Taylor expansion of $V_B(y)$ about the current yield, divided by the price, turns the two measures into a repricing estimate. For a yield change Δy , with $\Delta V_B := V_B(y + \Delta y) - V_B(y)$, the approximate fractional price change is given by:

$$\frac{\Delta V_B}{V_B} \approx \underbrace{-D_{\text{mod}} \Delta y}_{\text{slope}} + \underbrace{\frac{1}{2} K (\Delta y)^2}_{\text{curvature}}.$$

Because $K > 0$, the curvature term is positive for a shock of *either* sign: it adds to the gain and subtracts from the loss.

The convention. Δy is a decimal change in the annual yield. One **basis point** is 10^{-4} , so a 50-basis-point shock is $\Delta y = 0.0050$.

Careful: a 50-basis-point move in the *policy rate* does not imply $\Delta y = 0.0050$ for a given security.

Using Them: a Worked Repricing Estimate

Take a note with $D_{\text{mod}} = 7.2$ years and $K = 65$ years², and shock its own yield by +50 basis points, so $\Delta y = 0.0050$:

- slope term: $-7.2 \times 0.0050 = -0.0360$
- curvature term: $\frac{1}{2} \times 65 \times (0.0050)^2 = +0.0008$
- estimate: a **-3.52%** price change, where the straight line alone would have said -3.60%

Both measures are **local**: they are derivatives at the current yield, so the estimate degrades as Δy grows. For the multiple-percentage-point moves of 2022 and 2023 that hurt SVB, the honest calculation is to reprice the whole schedule at the new yield, not to extrapolate from duration.

Connection to Malkiel's Bond Pricing Theorems

Two ground rules. Every theorem assumes an option-free security with fixed positive cash flows and holds the other contract terms fixed. And the maturity theorems compare bonds **selling at par**, $\bar{c} = y$, measuring changes from that starting point. That restriction is not a technicality.

Substituting $C = (\bar{c}/n)V_P$ and summing the geometric series puts the coupon bond in closed form. Differentiating that at fixed $\bar{c}$, then setting $\bar{c} = y$, gives the modified duration of a par bond:

$$\frac{V_B}{V_P} = \frac{\bar{c}}{y} + \left(1 - \frac{\bar{c}}{y}\right) q^{-N} \quad \Rightarrow \quad D_{\text{mod}}(N) = \frac{1 - q^{-N}}{y}.$$

Order matters. Differentiate at fixed $\bar{c}$, and only *then* set $\bar{c} = y$. Setting $\bar{c} = y$ first differentiates along the par locus, where the price is pinned at V_P , and returns zero. Assume $y > 0$ throughout.

Malkiel's Theorems 1, 2, and 3

- **Theorem 1**, prices move inversely to yields: this is the sign $dV_B/dy < 0$, or equivalently $D_{\text{mod}} > 0$. Every promised payment is positive, so raising y discounts each more heavily.
- **Theorem 2**, longer maturity increases yield sensitivity: $D_{\text{mod}}(N) = (1 - q^{-N})/y$ is strictly increasing in N . A par bond starts at $V_B = V_P$ at every maturity, so the dollar sensitivity $-dV_B/dy = V_P D_{\text{mod}}(N)$ rises too: starting at par aligns the percentage and dollar rankings.
- **Theorem 3**, the gain diminishes: one extra period raises modified duration by $D_{\text{mod}}(N + 1) - D_{\text{mod}}(N) = q^{-N-1}/n$, and successive increments shrink by the constant factor $q^{-1} < 1$, so D_{mod} climbs toward the ceiling $1/y$.

Note: $1/y$ is the modified duration of a *perpetuity*, a security that pays its coupon forever and never repays principal.

Malkiel's Theorems 4 and 5

- **Theorem 4**, price movements are asymmetric: a yield decrease raises the price by more than an equal increase lowers it, from the same starting yield. The reason is **positive convexity**. In the second-order estimate the slope term flips sign with the shock while the curvature term $\frac{1}{2}K(\Delta y)^2$ stays positive. Nonlinearity alone would not do it: a concave curve gives the opposite asymmetry.
- **Theorem 5**, higher-coupon bonds are less sensitive: this is a statement about *percentage* sensitivity, and it needs $N \geq 2$. A larger coupon moves present value to earlier dates, lowering the weighted average payment time and so lowering D_{mod} . In *dollars* it runs the other way: more cash flow means a larger $-dV_B/dy$.

Excluded edge: at $N = 1$ everything arrives on one date and $D_{\text{mod}} = 1/(nq)$, however large the coupon.

What the Par Restriction Is Doing

Outside the par comparison, the percentage and dollar statements part company. For a zero-coupon bill, $D_{\text{mod}} = T/q$ grows without bound, but the dollar sensitivity is a product of a growing and a shrinking factor:

$$-\frac{dV_B}{dy} = V_P \underbrace{\frac{T}{q}}_{\text{growing}} \underbrace{q^{-nT}}_{\text{shrinking}}.$$

So it rises, peaks, and falls. With $V_P = 100$, $n = 1$, $y = 5\%$ it peaks near $T \approx 20.5$ years at about 718 USD per unit of yield, then falls to about 541 by $T = 40$.

A 40-year bill is far more sensitive than a 20-year bill in **percentage** terms and **less** sensitive in **dollars**. Only the par comparison guarantees the two rankings agree.

Example: CHEME-5660-L2b-Example-Treasury-Duration-Convexity-Fall-2026.ipynb, which tests Theorems 4 and 5.

From One Yield to the Yield Curve

Yield to maturity is the single internal rate that reproduces one security's price from its promised cash flows. It is useful for quoting and comparison, but it is not the full term structure.

A **spot rate** applies to one payment date, so a spot curve supplies one discount factor per date. A **par yield** is the coupon rate that makes a hypothetical security trade at par under that curve. Writing $D(0, t_j)$ for the time-0 discount factor for maturity t_j , the curve-based price is:

$$V_B = \sum_{j=1}^N X_j D(0, t_j).$$

Curve level, slope, and curvature describe how discounting varies by maturity. They do not, by themselves, identify a unique forecast of future short rates.

Optional Advanced Paths

The required sequence moves to equity markets in L3a. Students who want more can continue under week-2/L2b/advanced/:

Example: zero-coupon maturity sensitivity, using Treasury bill auction data

Example: yield-curve and stochastic short-rate notebooks

Example: Treasury STRIPS construction

Link: [lectures/week-2/L2b/advanced](#)

Summary

This lecture developed the core tools used to describe and manage the interest-rate risk of fixed-income securities.

Key takeaways

- **Bond prices decrease as yields increase.** For a fixed stream of positive cash flows, the price-yield relationship is decreasing and convex.
- **Duration and convexity measure local price sensitivity.** Duration gives the first-order response to a yield change, and convexity corrects that straight line for curvature.
- **One yield is not a yield curve.** Yield to maturity summarizes one security with a single rate, while spot rates and discount factors value cash flows at specific maturities and par yields are implied by that term structure.

Together these form a practical fixed-income risk toolkit.

That's a wrap. What are some of the interesting things we discussed today?